

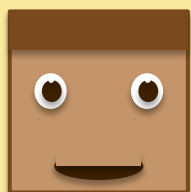


Encoded Archival Standards in Action!

Introducing the Updated Standards Suite

July 31, 2026

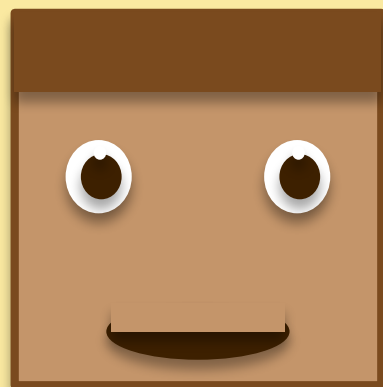
Karin Bredenberg · Mary Samouelian · co-chairs TS-EAS



*Hello. I'm Archie.
Standards are my
thing.*



*It's your turn to share!
What are some of the
challenges you have
implementing
standards where you
work?*





About TS-EAS

29 members · West Coast USA to East Coast Australia

SAA + international volunteers — maintaining the standards, building the community.



Agenda



Act I — Why This Matters to You

The case for encoding standards · Introducing the EAS Suite: EAD, EAC-CPF & EAC-F

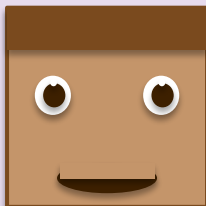
Act II — Meet the Suite

EAD 4: what's new and why it matters · EAC-CPF 3.0: updates and improvements · EAC-F 1.0: the missing piece

Act III — Start Today

Getting started without waiting for your vendor · The Best Practices Guide & how to contribute

Q & A



*Let's make standards
interesting!*



Act I

Introduction to the Encoded Archival Standards

Why your future self will thank you



Purposes of Encoding Standards

Consistency.

The same type of information, recorded the same way — every time.

Interoperability.

Systems can exchange data without custom translation for every pair.

Longevity.

Information stays usable as systems change. No custom scripts every migration.

Discovery.

Researchers find materials across institutions and uncover unexpected connections.

Expression of professional values.

Standards codify what our community believes good description looks like.



The Encoded Archival Standards Suite

Three standards that work together!



Alignment by Design

One revision cycle. Shared elements. Three standards built to work together.



What Was Missing?

Three standards. Three independent revision cycles.

Any change to one put the others out of step — "misalignment by design." Harder for systems to communicate, inconsistent understanding, limited global adoption.

Overlapping elements — inconsistently named, used, and defined.

The same concept described differently across EAD and EAC-CPF, creating confusion for systems and users alike.

Functions had no standard at all.

EAC-F did not exist — this revision cycle set out to change that.



Encoded Archival Standards

International, XML-based standards for structuring and sharing archival descriptive information.

EAD

Encoded Archival Description

EAC-CPF

Encoded Archival Context —
Corporate bodies, Persons & Families

EAC-F

Encoded Archival Context —
Functions

"Alignment by Design"

One revision cycle. A shared base of elements and attributes. Three standards built to work together.



Benefits of Shared Standards

Sustainable

One revision cycle keeps everything in sync.

No more misalignment by design — changes to one standard are reflected across all three.

Usable

Shared elements mean less to learn, more to reuse.

Human-readable element names and consistent conventions across all three standards.

Efficient

Build once. Apply across all three standards.

Shared elements and attributes reduce duplication and make systems easier to build and maintain.



The EAS Family — Shared Elements

EAD 4

Describes the records

EAC-CPF 3.0

Describes the creators

EAC-F 1.0

Describes the functions

Shared DNA — common elements & attributes across all three

abstract · agent · biogHist · description · language · sources · + more



Shared Elements in Detail

abstract

Brief summary of content or context

agent

Person, family, or corporate body

biogHist

Biographical or historical note

description

Narrative description of the entity

language

Language of materials or description

sources

Citations and references used

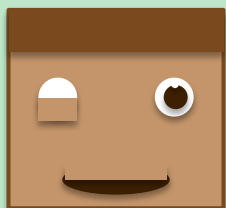
✦ **One suite. One repository for tag libraries. One folder for shared elements and attributes.**



From Cryptic to Clear — camelCase Naming

Not just camelCase — a rethink of what element names should actually communicate.

Before	After	Why it's clearer
<code><odd></code>	<code><otherDescriptiveInfo></code>	Replaces a vague acronym with an actual description
<code><accessrestrict></code>	<code><accessConditions></code>	Describes what it contains, not just an abbreviation
<code><acqinfo></code>	<code><sourceOfAcquisition></code>	Self-explanatory across languages and traditions
<code><bibliography></code>	<code><publicationNote></code>	Signals how the element is used in archival description
<code><unitdatestructured></code>	<code><unitDateStructured></code>	Same meaning, but readable at a glance
<code><bioghist></code>	<code><biogHist></code> ✓ kept	Already widely understood — renaming would confuse more than it helps



*"<odd>". Classic.
Nobody ever
wondered what
that meant.*



Relationships — The Origin Story

EAC-CPF 2010

Relationships introduced

<relation> grounded in ISAAR(CPF) — a dedicated place for referencing creators, finding aids, and related materials.

```
<relation>
  <targetEntity targetType="person"
valueURI="https://d-nb.info/gnd/120636123"">
    <part>Sophie</part>
    <part>Baden, Großherzogin</part>
  </targetEntity>
  <relationType>family</relationType>
  <targetRole>daughter</targetRole>
</relation>
```

EAD3 2015

Relationships attempted — but experimental

<relation> introduced but labeled experimental with no clear use case. ISAD(G) defines no dedicated relations section.

```
<relation relationtype="resourcerelation"
href="http://www.archivesportaleurope.net">
  <relationentry>Archivo de Vicente Rojo Lluch</relationentry>
</relation>
<relation relationtype="resourcerelation"
href="http://www.archivesportaleurope.net">
  <relationentry>Rojo Lluch, Vicente (1894-1966)</relationentry>
</relation>
```

EAD 4 + EAC-CPF 3.0 + EAC-F 1.0 — 2026

Consistent relationships across the Suite

Relationships are now embedded directly within the elements that describe them — purposeful, consistent, and compliant.

<relationship>

Specifies the type of relationship between entities within a specific element.

<relation>

Identifies external entities and characterizes the nature of their relationships to the entity or records being described.

EAD3 → EAD 4: Relations Before & After



EAD3 — Before

<origination>

Creator info in a general wrapper — no explicit relationship typing

<controlaccess>

Agents, places, subjects all grouped together in one bucket

<relation> ⚠

Experimental — standalone element with no clear use case



EAD 4 — After

<agent>

Dedicated element for creators and agents — contains <relationship>

<place>

Dedicated element for place — contains <relationship>

<function>

Dedicated element for functions — contains <relationship>

Extensibility

EAS Suite describes all types of archival information



<formattingExtension>

XHTML or other declared namespaces
for formatting in note-type elements

<objectXMLWrap>

Non-EAS standards embedded directly
in <relation> and <source>

External namespace attributes

Attributes from other namespaces (e.g.
MARCXML) declared in the root
element

Most text formatting elements have been removed — but not from your toolkit. <formattingExtension> gives you the flexibility to include XHTML formatting wherever you need it, without locking it into the standard itself.

Transparency in Descriptive Practices

Trust starts with documentation. Archives must clearly document the decisions behind their descriptions.



Artificial Intelligence

Specify which parts of the description process were generated or assisted by AI.

Reparative Description

Articulate how archivists' perspectives and biases shaped description, especially in reparative work.

Accessibility

Note accessibility features or potential barriers to support a more inclusive digital world.

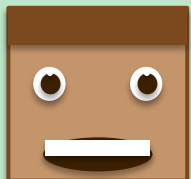
No new elements needed — use what's already there:

<conventionDeclaration>

Rules and conventions applied — including AI use, reparative approaches, accessibility.

<maintenanceEvent>

Versioning and attribution — who made changes, when, and why.



*Times are
changing. The
Suite is ready.*

Why Switch?

You've built your workflows around older versions. We get it. Here's what the updated Suite gives you:



Clearer language

Human-readable element names that make sense globally. *consistency · professional values*



Better connections

Consistent relations across all three standards, properly grounded in ISAD(G), ISDF, and ISAAR(CPF). *interoperability · discovery*



Future-proof flexibility

Extensibility that won't break when formatting conventions change. *longevity · interoperability*



Less to learn

Shared elements across all three standards — learn once, apply everywhere. *consistency · interoperability*



One tag library — not three

A single unified reference for the entire Suite. Less to maintain, less to get wrong. *consistency · longevity*



A complete suite

EAC-F finally gives functions a proper standard — completing the picture. *discovery · professional values*





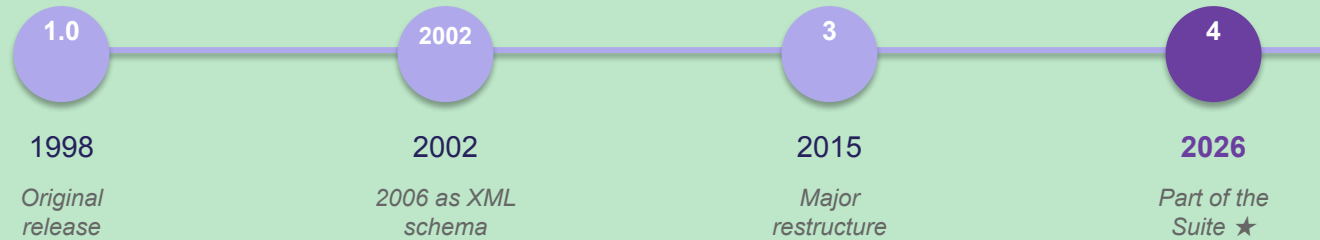
Act II — Meet the Suite

Encoded Archival Description (EAD)

Why your future self will thank you



Encoded Archival Description (EAD)



Purpose

An XML standard for encoding descriptions of archival materials — facilitating sharing, discovery, and long-term accessibility of collection descriptions.

Based on

International Standard Archival Description (General) — ISAD(G), 2000.

 www.loc.gov/ead



What's New in EAD 4

Further alignment with Records in Context (RiC) ★ headline change

EAD 4 takes meaningful steps toward RiC alignment — agents, functions, and places are now defined as entity elements. The concept of instantiation has been introduced to describe physical or digital forms. Value lists, especially relationship types, have been adapted to reflect RiC's approach.

<agent>

<function>

<place>

instantiation

✓ And we've already covered these...

camelCase naming

relations restructured

extensibility

<origination> gone

<controlaccess> gone

<formattingExtension>



Encoded Archival Context — Corporate bodies, Persons & Families (EAC-CPF)

The standard that's been ahead of the curve — and now has company.



Encoded Archival Context — CPF (EAC-CPF)

What is EAC-CPF?

An XML standard for describing the people, families, and organizations connected to archival records — not just the records themselves.

 Find every collection connected to a person or organization — across institutions.

 Map the network of relationships between agents — who knew whom, hierarchies, families.

 eac.staatsbibliothek-berlin.de

Release history

-  2004 — EAC Beta
Original experimental release
-  2010 — EAC-CPF 1.0
Introduced <relations> — ahead of EAD
-  2022 — EAC-CPF 2.0
First LOD/RiC alignment — @valueURI etc. ★ pioneer
-  **2026 — EAC-CPF 3.0**
Full Suite alignment

Eleanor Roosevelt (Person) ↔ associatedWith ↔ FDR ↔ memberOf ↔ UN Commission ↔ creatorOf ↔ FDR Library

One EAC-CPF record connects a person to their collections, relationships, and organizational roles — across institutions.



What's New in EAC-CPF 3.0

EAC-CPF was already ahead. CamelCase naming, relations, and LOD alignment were all in place before EAD 4. Version 3.0 completes the Suite picture.

Linked Open Data (LOD) alignment extended across the Suite ★ headline change

First introduced in EAC-CPF 2.0 (2022), LOD-supporting attributes are now shared across all three Suite standards — wherever textual descriptions are used or referencing a published vocabulary adds value.

@valueURI

@vocabularySource

@vocabularySourceURI

Suite alignment — minor but meaningful

Small targeted changes to bring EAC-CPF 3.0 fully in line with the shared Suite vocabulary — shared elements, consistent relations handling, and unified tag library coverage.



Encoded Archival Context — Functions (EAC-F)

The newest member of the EAS family.



Encoded Archival Context — Functions (EAC-F)

What is EAC-F?

An XML standard for encoding the functions performed by agents — the WHY behind the records.

Where EAD describes WHAT was created and EAC-CPF describes WHO created it, EAC-F describes WHY it was created.

Based on the International Standard for Describing Functions (ISDF), 2007.

<https://saa-sdt.github.io/EAS-TagLibraries/>

Origin story — 13 years in the making

2013

Ad-hoc group formed

Information gathering began. Group went dormant — the idea was ahead of its time.

2016

TS-EAS picks it up

TS-EAS formally took on the creation of EAC-F as part of its work program.

2026

EAC-F 1.0 released ★

A proper standard at last — the third and final piece of the EAS Suite.



Why EAC-F? What Was Missing?

The gap

EAD tells us what records exist. EAC-CPF tells us who created them. But neither could answer: WHY were these records created?

What was the organizational mandate, the activity, the function that drove record creation? Without that, the picture is incomplete.

The researcher payoff

With EAC-F, a researcher can follow the thread:
function → agent → record

What did this organization need to do? (function)
Who was responsible? (agent)
What records did that produce? (EAD)

One EAC-F record can connect multiple institutions through a common activity.

The glue that connects everything

EAC-F is the missing piece that makes the Suite complete — connecting what was created, who created it, and why it exists at all.



Why Functions?

|| *In contemporary archival practice, archival description focused primarily on what was created (records) and who created them (agents). But it's equally important to understand why records were created and how organizational responsibilities influenced their production.*

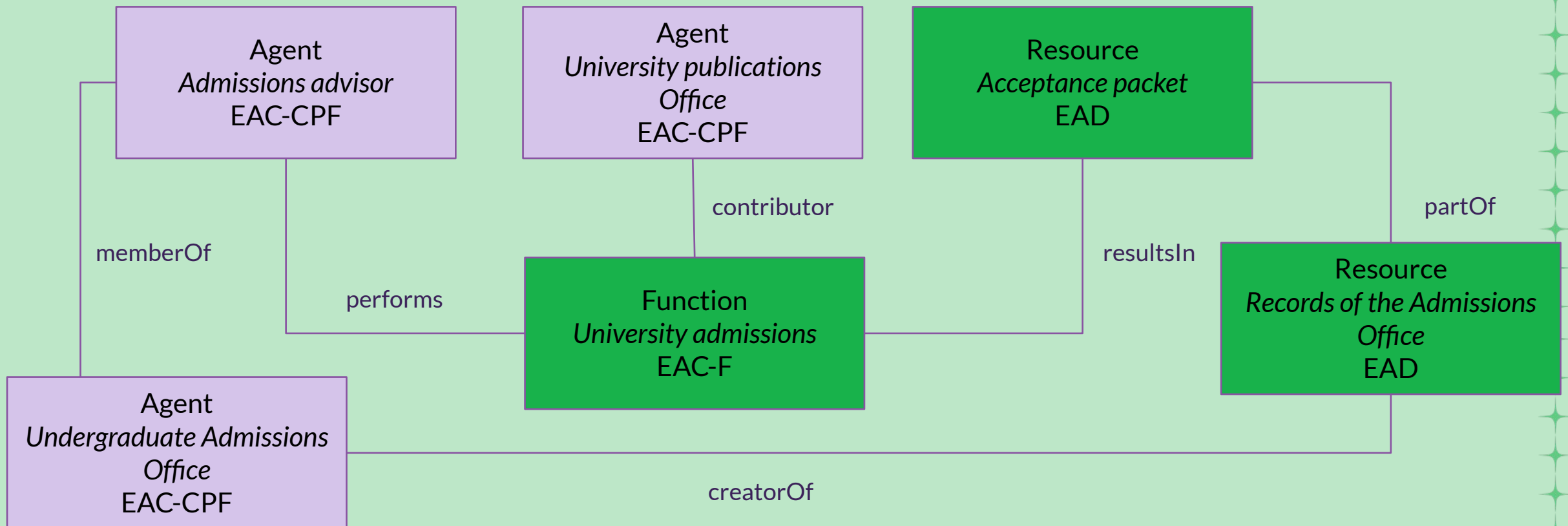
Describing functions helps reveal the purpose, responsibilities, and activities behind records.

— Encoded Archival Context — Functions (EAC-F), Version 1.0, 2026





The Suite in Action: Who, What, and Why — Connected





Introduction to the **Best Practices Guide (BPG)**

Written by archivists, for archivists.



Best Practices Guide (BPG)

What is the BPG?

A living community resource that goes beyond what the Tag Library can provide — real context, real examples, real language.

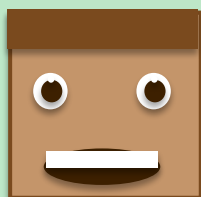
First developed in 2022 as a companion to EAC-CPF 2.0. Now covers the full EAS Suite: EAD, EAC-CPF, and EAC-F.

 saa-sdt.github.io/EAS-Best-Practices

Goals

-  Provide context around key topics in archival description
-  Share real use cases with example encodings
-  Promote wider adoption and comfort with the standards
-  Describe usage in natural language — not just technical specs
-  Unified format covering all three EAS standards
-  A living resource, built by and for the community

*The BPG is a
living doc. YOU
can help build it.*





Best Practices Guide – Live Demo



Best Practices Guide – A Concrete Example

Tag Library says...

When describing archival materials using <container>, the attribute @containerId might be used similarly to <formAvailableId>. While <container> is still available within <identificationData> in EAD 4.0, it is highly recommended to move to using <container> within <formAvailable> instead.



BPG says...

In plain language: if you've been using <container> inside <identificationData> — it still works, but the recommended approach in EAD 4 is to move it inside <formAvailable> instead. Here's what that looks like:

```
<formAvailable>
  <container localType="box">1</container>
  <container localType="folder">3</container>
</formAvailable>
```



Act III — Start Today

No vendor required. No IT ticket needed. Start today.

Your system

What ArchivesSpace, AtoM & SNAC can do right now

Hand-coding XML

A practical checklist for XML practitioners

The BPG

Your go-to resource for guidance and examples





EAS Implementations — ArchivesSpace

Current EAS Support

Originally designed around EAD 2002.

Import: EAD 2002

Export: EAD 2002 and EAD3

Modules: Agents (EAC-CPF) · Resources (EAD)

No native EAC-F support yet — but there's a workaround.

What you can do right now

- ✓ Link resources to agents with typed relationships (Creator, Source, Subject)
- ✓ Create agent-to-agent relationships with specific types
- ✓ Link resources to other resources
- ✓ Describe functions using Subject with type=Function as a workaround

💡 EAC-F workaround: Until native EAC-F support arrives, create a Subject with Type=Function. It establishes the relationship and keeps your data ready for migration when support arrives.

Resource Relationship to Agent



Agent Links

Primary	Role	Relator	Agent
	Creator		 Siebert, Muriel (1928-2013)
	Subject		 New York Stock Exchange
	Subject		 Wall Street (New York, N.Y.)
	Subject		 Muriel Siebert & Co.
	Creator		 Siebert, Irwin J., Dr. (Irwin Jackson) (1891-1949)

Agent to Agent Relations



Related Agents

General
Relationship Type

Family Relationship

Specific
Relationship Type

Relationship URI

Related Agent *

Description

Associative Relationship

Earlier/Later Relationship

✓ Family Relationship

Hierarchical Relationship

Identity Relationship

Parent/Child Relationship

Temporal Relationship

Add Related Agent

?

✕

Type to search available records..

▼

Dates

Add Date



Resource to Resource Relations

Related Materials

Persistent ID f8ba07f3c80c79966b4a2ec8e1aafa47

Type Related Materials

Publish? True

Sub Notes

Text

The records in this collection relate directly to materials held in other Polaroid Corporation records by Baker Library. These records fill in significant gaps, especially Board of Directors meeting records and annual stockholders meeting records. The following series are open for research: <extref xlink:type="simple" xlink:href="http://nrs.harvard.edu/urn-3:HBS.Baker.EAD:bak00206"> Polaroid Corporation records, series I: administrative records, circa 1930-2005</extref>; <extref xlink:type="simple" xlink:href="http://nrs.harvard.edu/urn-3:HBS.Baker.EAD:bak00207"> Polaroid Corporation records, series II: legal and patent records, circa 1905-1995</extref>. Some annual stockholder meetings have been digitized; For particular annual stockholder meetings see, <extref xlink:type="simple" xlink:href="https://id.lib.harvard.edu/ead/bak00306/catalog"> Polaroid Corporation records, series VI: audiovisual records</extref>

Researchers should note that there is considerable overlap in the subject matter contained in the various series, and are advised to search across all of the series finding aids for specific subjects or records.

Function Relation?



Create Subject

Basic Information

Authority ID

Source *

Scope Note

* Terms and Subdivisions

Add Term/Subdivision

Term *

Type *

Function

External Documents

Add External Document

Metadata Rights Declarations

Add Metadata Rights Declaration

Create and Link

Cancel



Other Systems — AtoM & snac

AtoM — Access to Memory

Originated by the International Council on Archives (ICA) to support the ICA suite of standards: ISAAR(CPF), ISAD(G), ISDIAH, and ISDF.

Import/Export: EAD 2002, EAC-CPF

Modules: Agents · Resources · Functions

Notably: AtoM already has a dedicated Functions module — one of the few systems with native function description support right now.

EAD 2002

EAC-CPF

Functions module

snac — Social Networks and Archival Context

Designed specifically as a user-friendly editor interface to support creation of EAC-CPF compliant records.

Export: EAC-CPF

Import: Transformed EAD files into EAC-CPF

Agent description only — but can create relationships to Resources in external systems. A powerful tool for building out the agent/relationship layer of your Suite implementation.

EAC-CPF focused

Agent relationships

External linking

Hand-Coding XML — Your Checklist

Working directly in XML? Here's what you can do right now — no system update required.



Exchange of data

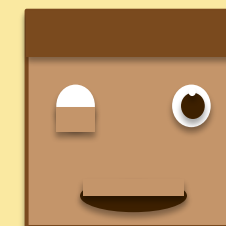
- ✓ Add identifiers — dates as ISO 8601, language codes
- ✓ Use machine-readable syntaxes in structured fields
- ✓ Keep free-text fields for humans — not for indexing
- ✓ No HTML formatting tags in description fields
- ✓ Run periodic data quality audits

Establish relationships

- ✓ Describe agents, resources and functions as separate entities
- ✓ Think in pieces of data that work together — not single finding aids
- ✓ Create descriptions reusable in other contexts
- ✓ Connect to external agents/resources/functions
- ✓ Use <relation> to link EAD/EAC-CPF to EAC-F descriptions

Extensibility & LOD

- ✓ Mint unique identifiers so data can be referenced and cited
- ✓ Add a license to your metadata so others can reuse it
- ✓ Prefer national/international controlled vocabularies over local
- ✓ Connect to Wikidata, LCNAF, SNAC and other resources
- ✓ Use @valueURI, @vocabularySource for LOD-ready descriptions

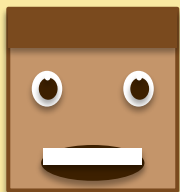


Pick one item from this list. Do it this week. That's how it starts.



How You Can Get Involved

The Suite belongs to the community. So does the BPG.



You made it this far. You clearly care. Go write something.

How to Contribute to the BPG



How contributions work

- 1 Submit your idea**
Open a GitHub issue or email the Editorial Board subgroup. Propose new content or flag an issue.
- 2 Editorial Board evaluates**
The Editorial Board subgroup — TS-EAS members — reviews and determines next steps.
- 3 Write or contribute**
You may be invited to write the article yourself, or a TS-EAS member may take it on. You stay in the loop.
- 4 Published to the BPG**
Vetted by the EAS team and published — your contribution becomes part of the living resource.

How to reach us

 GitHub
Open an issue on the BPG repository

 Email
ts-eas@archivists.org

"The BPG is a living document for creators of archival descriptions. People from the community are invited to propose content or highlight issues to tackle in EAS. Contributions will be vetted by EAS Teams for inclusion in the site."



Links for your reference!

EAD: <https://www.loc.gov/ead/>

EAC-CPF <https://eac.staatsbibliothek-berlin.de/>

EAC-F <https://saa-sdt.github.io/EAS-TagLibraries/>

BPG: <https://saa-sdt.github.io/EAS-Best-Practices/>

Microsite:

<https://www2.archivists.org/groups/technical-subcommittee-on-encoding-archival-standards-ts-eas>

GitHub: <https://github.com/SAA-SDT>

Notes: <https://github.com/SAA-SDT/TS-EAS-subteam-notes>

Intro YouTube video on

EAS: <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=kH-fghLBrLU&t=24s>

Wiki: <https://github.com/SAA-SDT/TS-EAS-subteam-notes/wiki>

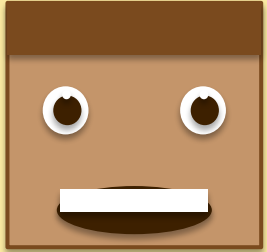


Q & A

Still have questions? Reach us at:

ts-eas@archivists.org

 saa-sdt.github.io/EAS-Best-Practices



*Go forth and
encode
responsibly.*



Thank you!

**Introducing the Updated Standards Suite
July 31, 2026**

**Karin Bredenberg
Mary Samouelian**